1.85mn Phone numbers TRAI has blacklisted since Aug. 2024

13mn Fraudulent international calls are blocked by DoT every day

Every day, Nabamita Bhattacharya steels herself for the daily assault on her phone. The first call comes at around 10.30 am—an automated voice offering a credit card with 'lifetime free benefits'. By noon, her phone is flooded with promotional messages offering health insurance, real estate deals, astrology services and instant loans—'1 CR BUSINESS LOAN IN MINS. NO DOCUMENTS! CALL...' For the 39-year-old Kolkata-based businesswoman, these interruptions are more than a minor nuisance. They disrupt her work, intrude on her personal time and take a toll on her mental peace. Yet, as a business owner, she cannot afford to ignore unknown numbers, leaving her at the mercy of this relentless barrage. "Once, I was in the middle of a client meeting when calls kept popping up," she recalls. "One number looked familiar, so I excused myself to answer it, only to hear a woman asking me if I needed to service my water filter. I was mortified."

Sounds familiar? Spam calls and messages have become a daily annoyance for millions of Indians. Once seen as an unavoidable aspect of a hyper-connected world, spam today has escalated into a serious issue—enough for the government and private telecom companies to contemplate urgent action.

India, home to over a billion cellphone users, is one of the world's most spam-plagued countries. Complaints about Unsolicited Commercial Communications (UCC) have surged, according to the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI). In 2023 alone, a staggering 12.2 million grievances were filed against unregistered telemarketers (UTMs), a sharp climb from 8.5 million in 2021. For a nation thriving on digital connectivity, spam is becoming an unwelcome side-effect. Spammers often impersonate legitimate businesses, exploiting loopholes to bypass rules. Authorities struggle to curb their activities. "On average, a user gets around 8-10 calls a day that are technically spam.... And the volumes are increasing," says Vinish Bawa, partner and leader-telecom at PwC India. "User experience is being impacted."

To counter the menace, the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) has launched the International Incoming Spoofed Calls Prevention System, which blocks 13 million such calls daily. "An international company uses an international server, masquerading as a +91 (India code) number, so users think it's from India. Since launch, this software has been intercepting and blocking millions of calls,"

Silencing the Noise Storm

From AI-powered detection to stricter laws, India is deploying robust measures to curb spam calls and messages



AI-driven spam detection
Airtel, Vodafone Idea and Jio have implemented AI-based systems to block spam in real time and flag suspected spam

Enhanced message traceability
A November 2024 TRAI mandate requires every commercial message to have a traceable trail from sender to recipient

Mandatory URL and APK whitelisting
From October 2024, only approved URLs, Android Package Kits (APK) and OTT links are allowed in SMSes

Transition to DLT platform
TRAI directed telcos to migrate all telemarketing calls to the Distributed Ledger Technology platform by September 2024, improving monitoring/ control of commercial communications

Blocking unused headers and templates
Since February 2023, service providers have blocked over 350,000 unused headers and 1.2 million unverified SMS templates to prevent misuse

Punishments for violators
From August 2024, telemarketers caught violating regulations face blacklisting for two years